

A NEW KIND OF FIREPOWER

GATLING GUN

By the second half of the 19th century, improvements in engineering had made it possible to manufacture reliable multiple-fire weapons. This gun, patented by Richard Gatling in 1862, employed multiple barrels, as would all early machine guns. It also took advantage of the new brass cartridge – earlier paper cartridges were dangerous, being liable to combust unpredictably. The Gatling gun was first developed in the American Civil War, and was deemed a success. It subsequently saw action with the British Army in various overseas campaigns.

► GATLING GUN

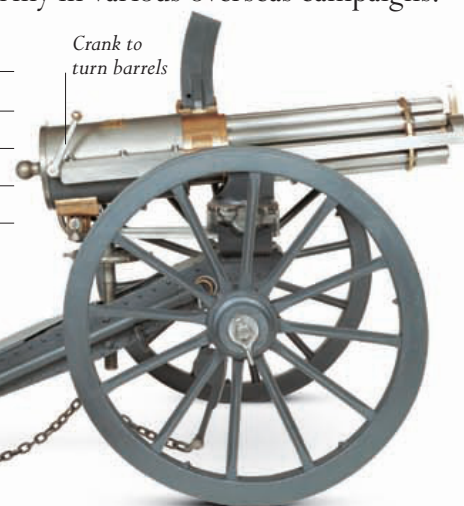
Date 1865 Origin US

Weight 1,000kg (2,200lb)

Barrels 10

Calibre .45, .65, or 1in

OPPOSITE SIDE VIEW



◄ FORE SIGHT AND BARRELS

The fore sight enabled the gunner to make adjustments to the gun's targeting. Having 10 barrels reduced the risk of overheating. In combat use the gun could average around 400 rounds per minute.

IN ACTION

ON THE BATTLEFIELD

The Gatling gun's method of operation enabled unskilled users to maintain a reasonably high rate of fire. This had its most notable effect in colonial wars against adversaries with less advanced arms, such as its use against the Plains Indians in North America, by the US Army, and against the Zulus in southern Africa, by the British Army. Some of the guns were also used as naval weapons, though with a slightly reduced rate of fire.

► The British Army used the Gatling to devastating effect in the Zulu Wars.



THE GATLING GUN

The gun's barrels – at first six, later ten – were arranged around a cylindrical shaft. A hand-operated crank made the barrels revolve, and cartridges dropped into place from above as each barrel came around. A firing pin then struck and fired the bullet; the barrel turned and the process was repeated. As each barrel descended, its spent case was ejected.

